LODESTAR USER GUIDE · 121 SQN

Department Planner

Planning your department's crew, duties, currency and training

DRAFT · NOT FOR ISSUE · 6 NOVEMBER 2026

Who this guide is for

This guide is for the planners of SUP 1, SUP 2, TACCO, Loadmaster and Pilot. Every department's file is built from the same template, so it works for all five. It also covers the Duty Planner (BDO and SDO).

In this guide

Part 1 Getting started: how LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved.

Part 2 Department planners: for the planners of SUP 1, SUP 2, TACCO, Loadmaster and Pilot.

Part 3 Duty Planner: BDO (Base Duty Officer) and SDO (Squadron Duty Orderly).

Start with **Part 1, Getting started**. The contents on the next page give the page of every section. Every page in the dashboard also has its own help: press the **?** button at the right end of the tab bar.

LODESTAR · 121 SQN · **Department Planner guide** · Dated 6 November 2026 · For dashboard version z196 (BETA) · Screenshots use demo data only: the names, callsigns and flights are made up.

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PART 1

Getting started

How LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved

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1.1 What LODESTAR is

LODESTAR is the squadron's daily flying and ops planner. It replaces copying plans by hand between the department Excel files and the Ops Room. It has two pieces:

- **Eight Excel files** in the SharePoint folder **Program**. They hold all the data. They have no macros and still open normally in Excel.
- **The dashboard**, one web page in the same folder. It opens the Excel files, shows them as planners, calendars and boards, and saves your changes back into them.

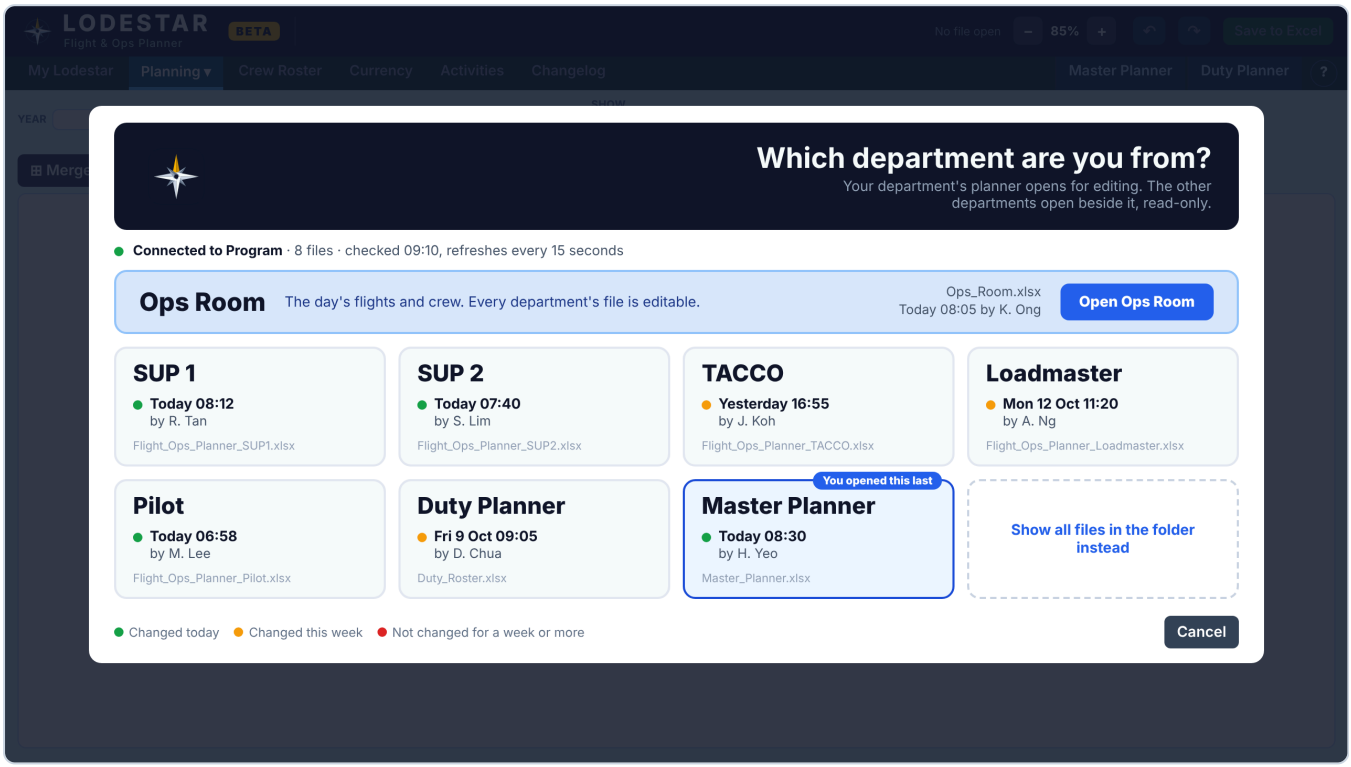
File	What it holds
Flight_Ops_Planner_SUP1, _SUP2, _TACCO, _Loadmaster, _Pilot	One file per department: the crew list, each person's plan for every day (AM, PM, NIGHT and a whole-day WD row), currency, syllabus and the month totals.
Master_Planner	The squadron's flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, flight codes and the Crew Matrix. It is the one true list of flights.
Duty_Roster	Who does BDO on each day, and which department does SDO on each day.
Ops_Room	The day board: tails, seats, ATD and ATA, flown or cancelled, Ops Adds, flying restrictions, down-chits and the ATOM currency export.

HOW THE PLAN FLOWS

The **Master Planner** plans the flights. Each **department** copies its flights into its own planner and puts its people on them. The **Duty Planner** hands out BDO and SDO days, and each department copies its days too. The **Ops Room** reads all of it and fills the seats on the day's board by itself. Nobody has to retype anything.

1.2 Opening LODESTAR

1. Open the SharePoint folder **Program** and open the LODESTAR dashboard file in Edge.
2. The screen **"Which department are you from?"** appears. Each card shows when its file last changed and who changed it: green is today, amber is this week, red is a week or more ago.
3. Click your own card. Your file opens **for editing** and the other files open beside it **to view only**, so you can see the rest of the squadron.



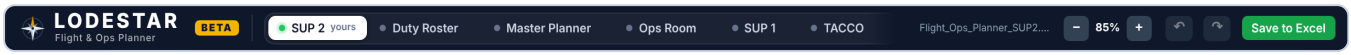
The department screen. The card you opened last is marked "You opened this last".

- The dashboard remembers your choice in this browser. To pick another card, click the **LODESTAR** logo at the top left.
- **⟳ Refresh** or F5 reads the latest files again and keeps you where you are.
- On SharePoint the dashboard looks for changes from other people every 15 seconds and shows them without you doing anything.

> **DASHBOARD AND FILES GO TOGETHER**
>
> The dashboard and the Excel files are made as a matched set. If a yellow bar says a file uses an **older layout** or is **newer than the dashboard**, tell the LODESTAR maintainer. Do not keep planning in a mixed set.

1.3 The screen

Top bar



The top bar.

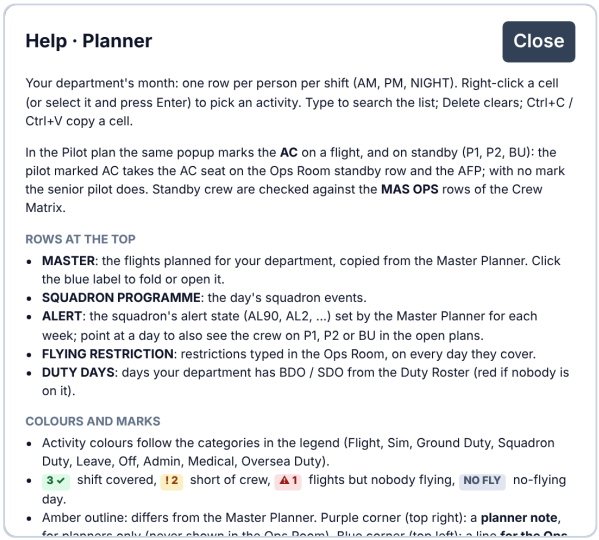
- **The file pills** list the open files. Yours is white and marked **yours**. A grey dot means view only.
- **− 100% +** zooms the whole page. Use it to fit the planner on a small screen.
- ↶ ↷ undo and redo.
- **Save to Excel** saves now. It turns bright green when there is something to save.

Tab bar



The tab bar. The padlock on Master Planner means you can look but not change it.

Tab	What it is
My Lodestar	Your own page: today's flight, your month, your currency and what changed. View only.
Planning ▾	Planner (the month plan), Overview, Syllabus Tracking and Miscellaneous Notes (Part 2).
Crew Roster, Currency, Activities	Your department's crew list, currency checks and activity list (Part 2).
Changelog	Every saved change, with who and when (section 1.4).
Ops Room	The day board (the Ops Room guide). Departments see it view only.
Master Planner ▾	The squadron calendar, Flight Codes and Crew Matrix (the Master Planner guide).
Duty Planner	BDO and SDO (Part 3).
?	Help for the page you are on, with the meaning of its colours.



The help (?) for the Planner.

1.4 Saving, undo and the Changelog

Saving

- **On SharePoint your work saves by itself** a few seconds after each change. `Save to Excel` saves at once.
- Only the cells you changed are written. The rest of the file, including its formulas and drop-downs, is left alone. If someone else saved the same file in the meantime, their changes are kept and yours are added on top.
- If you close the tab with unsaved changes, the browser asks you to confirm.

Undo and redo

`↶` and `↷`, or **Ctrl+Z** and **Ctrl+Y**, undo and redo your recent changes (up to 40 steps).

Changelog

Every save is written to a **Change Log** sheet in the file itself: when, who, what changed in words, and the value before and after. The `Changelog` tab shows the log of your own file, the Master Planner and the Ops Room. You can filter by person, file, day or text, and hover over a line to see the exact sheet and cell. Lines older than 90 days are dropped; SharePoint's version history keeps older copies of the file.

1.5 Who can change what

You opened	You can change	You can see
Your department	Your department's plan, Crew Roster, Currency, Activities, Syllabus and Notes.	Every other file, view only.
Master Planner	Flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, Flight Codes and the Crew Matrix.	Every other file, view only.
Duty Roster	The BDO and SDO roster and the duty crew lists.	Every other file, view only.
Ops Room	The day board. It can also up-chit a person in a department file.	Every file.

On SharePoint this also follows the folder's edit rights. If you have no edit rights on a file, you cannot save it, even if you picked its card.

> **EXCEL STILL WORKS**
>
> You can open any of the files in desktop Excel to read or print them. Prefer the dashboard for changes: it keeps the copies between files in step. If you do edit in Excel, close the file before others save from the dashboard.

1.6 Common questions

Question	Answer
Everything is locked (🔒) and I cannot click.	You opened another department's card. Click the LODESTAR logo and pick your own.
I can't see a change someone just made.	Wait 15 seconds, or press ⟳ Refresh (F5).
A yellow bar says "older layout".	The files and the dashboard don't match. Tell the LODESTAR maintainer.
Save to Excel stays green.	The save did not go through. Check you are still signed in to SharePoint and have edit rights, then press it again.
The page is too big for my screen.	Use − in the top bar to zoom out.

PART 2

Department planners

For the planners of SUP 1, SUP 2, TACCO, Loadmaster and Pilot

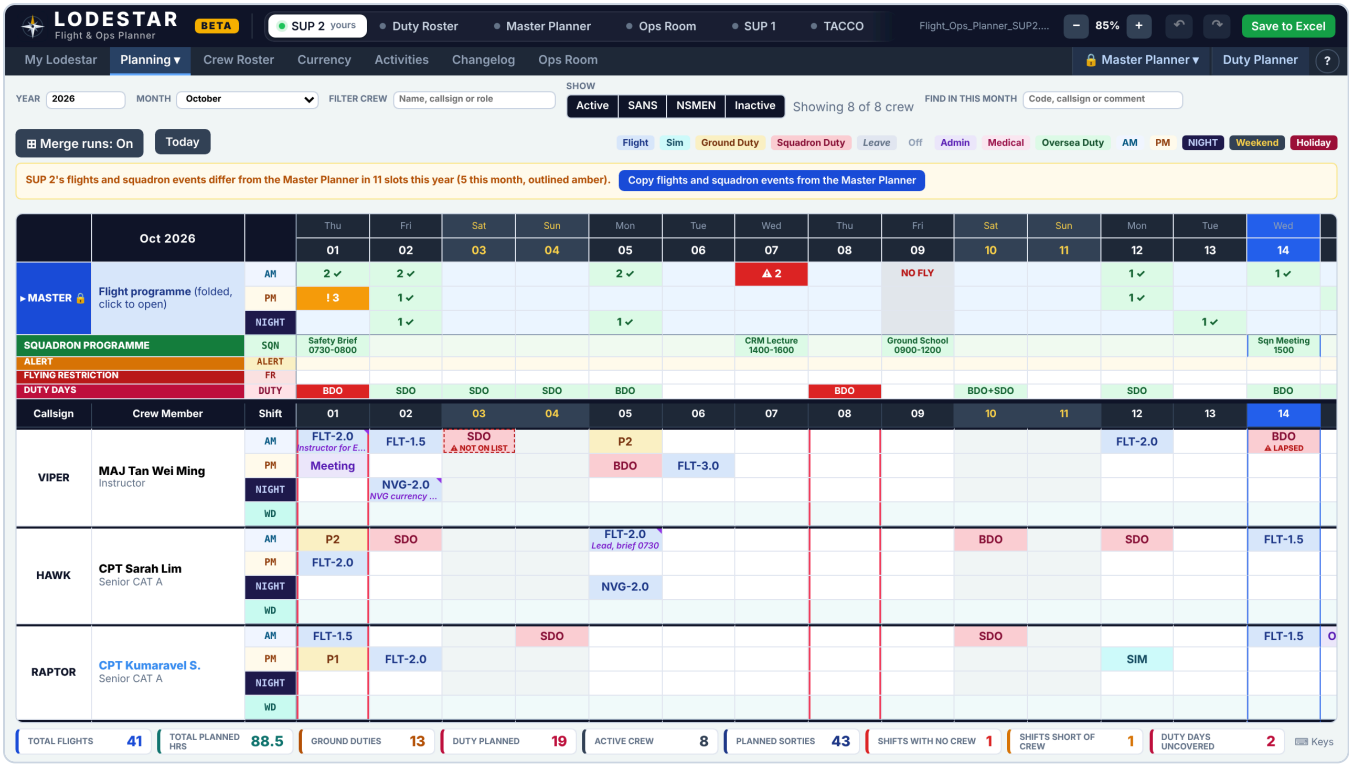
Every department has its own file built from the same template, so this part works for all five departments. The screenshots show SUP 2.

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QS Quick start

1. **Open the dashboard** and pick your department on the department screen. The Planner opens on this month.
2. **Copy the flights.** If an amber bar says your flights differ from the Master Planner, press `Copy flights and squadron events from the Master Planner`.
3. **Copy your duty days** on the `Duty Planner` tab with `Copy my duty days from the Duty Roster`.
4. **Put people on flights.** Right-click a person's cell (or select it and press Enter) and pick the flight, duty or leave from the list.
5. **Check the MASTER row.** Each shift should show green `2 ✓`. Amber means short of crew, red means flights with nobody from your department.
6. **Let it save**, or press `Save to Excel`.

2.1 Reading the Planner



The Planner, October. Rows at the top for the squadron, then one block per person.

Controls along the top

- **YEAR** and **MONTH** pick the month. **Today** jumps to today's month and column (blue).
- **FILTER CREW** shows only people whose name, callsign or role matches. **SHOW** switches the Active, SANS, NSMEN and Inactive groups on or off.
- **FIND IN THIS MONTH** outlines every cell with that code, time, comment or name. Enter jumps to the next.
- **Merge runs** shows a run of the same leave or course over several days as one block, for example "LL 1–2 Nov · 2 days".

Rows at the top

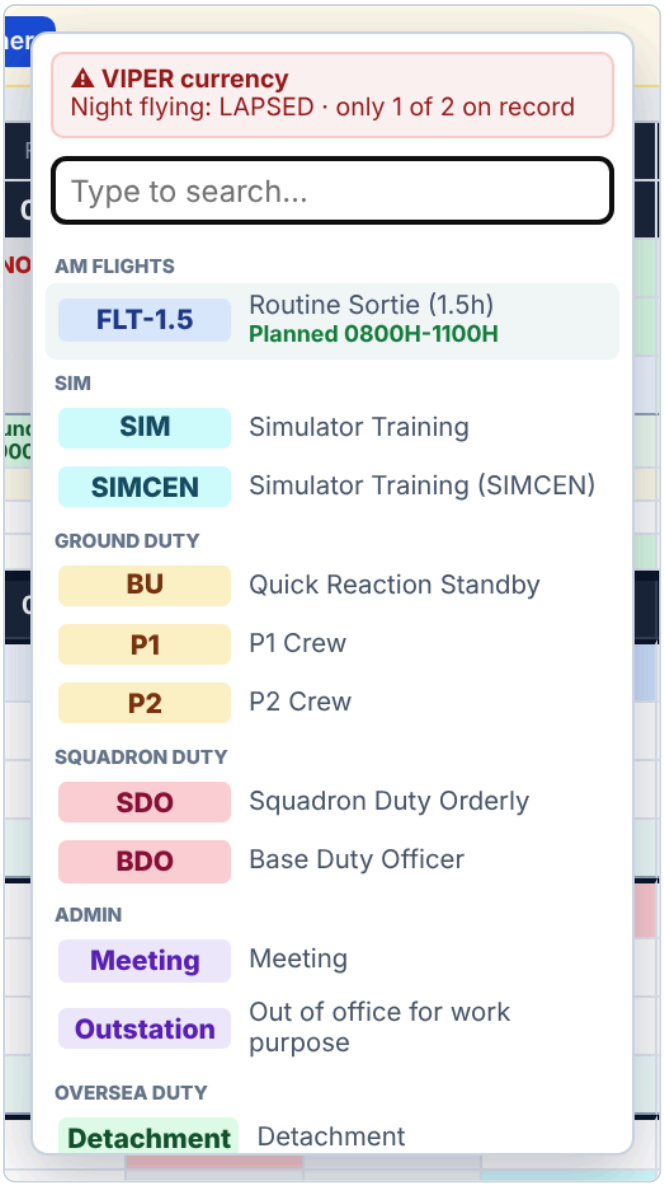
Row	What it shows
MASTER 🔒	The flights the Master Planner planned for your department, per shift. Folded, it shows how well each shift is crewed. Click the blue label to open it and see each flight's code and time.
SQUADRON PROGRAMME	The day's squadron events (meetings, lectures, ceremonies) that your department attends.
ALERT	The squadron's alert state (for example AL90 or AL2), set by the Master Planner for each week. Point at a day to see who is on P1, P2 or BU.
FLYING RESTRICTION	Restrictions typed in the Ops Room, on every day they cover.
DUTY DAYS	Your department's BDO and SDO days from the Duty Roster. Red means nobody is planned on it yet.

Crew rows

Each person has four rows: **AM**, **PM**, **NIGHT** and **WD** (whole day). Put flights and shift duties on AM, PM or NIGHT. Put whole-day items such as BDO, courses and admin on the WD row. Regular crew are at the top; SANS and NSmen are always at the bottom.

The strip along the bottom adds up the month: total flights, planned hours, ground duties, duty days, active crew, planned sorties, and the problem counts (shifts with no crew, shifts short of crew, duty days uncovered). `⌨ Keys` lists the keyboard shortcuts.

2.2 Planning a person



The cell list (right-click). The day's flights come first, with their planned times.

1. **Right-click** the person's cell for the day and shift, or click it and press **Enter**.
2. The list opens with **the day's flights for that shift at the top**, then Sim, Ground Duty, Squadron Duty, Admin, Leave and so on.
3. Type a few letters to search, then click the item or press Enter.

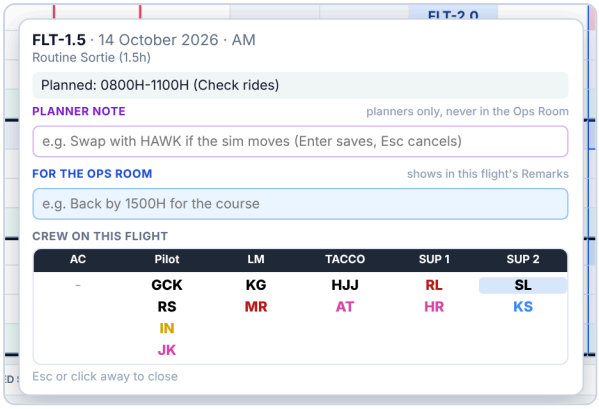
At the top of the list you may see a warning about this person, for example a lapsed currency. It only warns.

Shortcuts

- **Delete** clears the selected cell.
- **Ctrl+C** and **Ctrl+V** copy one cell to another.
- Arrow keys move the selection.
- **Block of days...** at the bottom of the list puts one item over a range of dates, for example a course, a detachment or leave.

> **FLIGHTS**
>
> Only put someone on a flight that is on the MASTER row for that shift. That is what the Ops Room uses to seat them.

2.3 Notes on a cell



Click a cell to open its card. It has two boxes for notes.

Click (left-click) a cell to open its card. It shows what is planned and has two separate notes:

Box	Who sees it	Mark on the cell
Planner note	Planners only. Never shown in the Ops Room. Use it for reminders, for example "Swap with HAWK if the sim moves".	Purple corner, top right
For the Ops Room	Shown in that flight's Remarks on the Ops Room board and on the AFP. Use it for things the duty staff must know, for example "Back by 1500H for the course".	Blue corner, top left

Type in a box and press Enter to save it, or Esc to cancel. Clear the box to remove the note.

2.4 Copying from the Master Planner

The Master Planner plans the squadron's flights and squadron events. Your planner does not change by itself when they do. Instead:

- An amber bar says how many slots differ ("...differ from the Master Planner in 11 slots this year"), and the changed slots are outlined amber.
- Press **Copy flights and squadron events from the Master Planner**. Your MASTER and SQUADRON PROGRAMME rows are updated for the whole year.
- Your people stay where you put them. If a flight moved or was removed, check the people you had planned on it.

You only get flights whose crew tags include your department. If you think a flight is missing, ask the Master Planner to check the tags. New flight codes reach your Activities list by themselves the next time you save.

Running changes: Flight 1/2, Flight 2/2

When the Master Planner gives a flight 2 or 3 sorties, the MASTER cell says **2 SORTIES**. By default everyone you put on it is crew on every sortie. To change that for a person, right-click their cell and use **On this flight**: Crew, Pax or Not on, for each flight. The cell then shows a tag such as **PAX FLIGHT 1/2** or **FLIGHT 1/2 ONLY**, and the Ops Room seats them on the right rows.

2.5 Colours and warnings

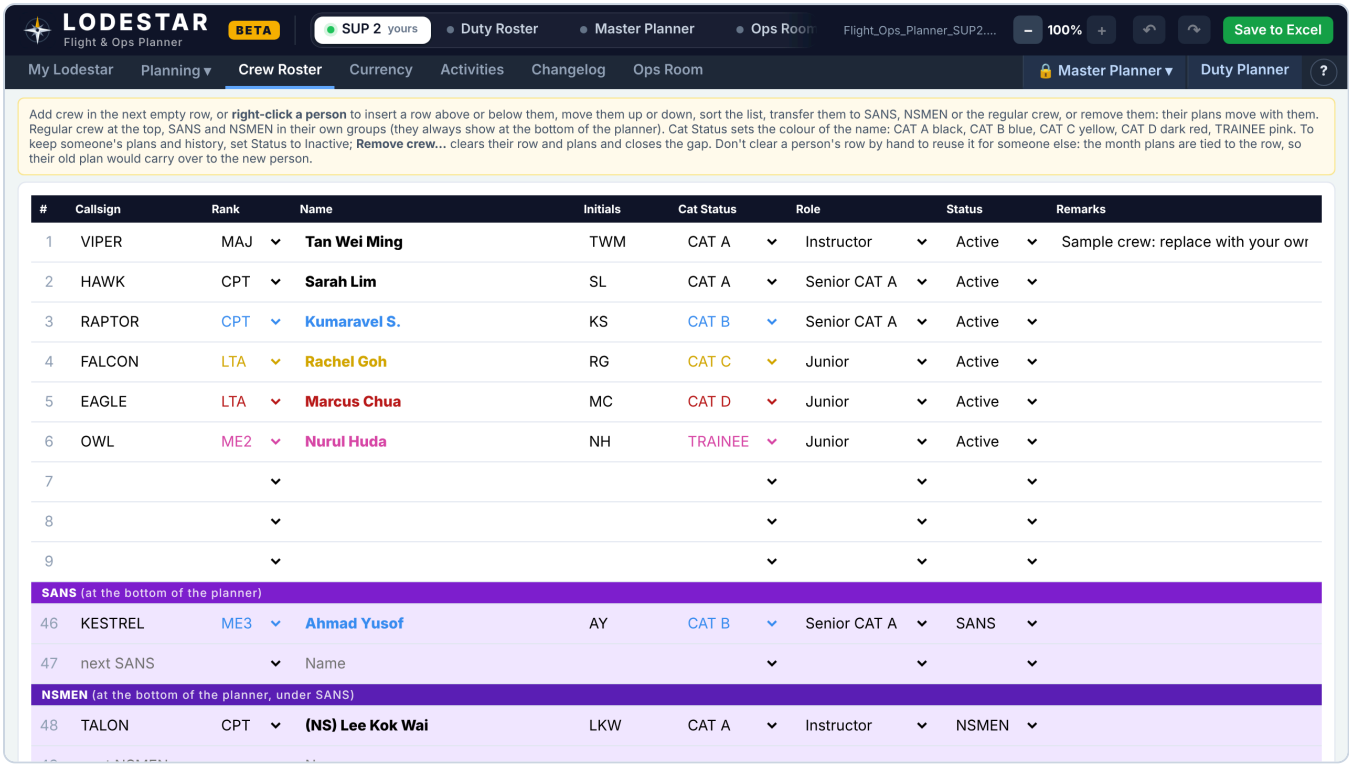
Mark	Meaning
3 ✓	On the MASTER row: the shift is covered. The number is the planned sorties.
! 2	Short of crew: some flights in the shift have fewer of your people than needed.
⚠ 1	There are flights in the shift but nobody from your department is on them.
NO FLY	A no-flying day set by the Master Planner.
Amber outline	Differs from the Master Planner (section 2.4).
Red dashed outline, "NOT ON LIST"	The person is on a duty (BDO or SDO) but is not on the crew list for that duty (Part 3).
REST	The person flies 5 or more days in a row.
DOWN	Down-chitted after MC: not cleared to fly. The down-chit days are striped red, and a flight on them gets a red box. Click DOWN, or **Up-chit...** in the cell list, to up-chit.
"LAPSED", "NOT CURRENT", red corner	A currency has expired before this flight (section 2.8). It only warns.
Purple mark on the WD row	A mission currency expires that day (from ATOM).
"CREW MATRIX" (amber)	The planned crew on that flight or standby does not fit the Crew Matrix for its mission. It only warns.
Struck-through flight	Cancelled in the Ops Room.
Amber underline	A past flight that the Ops Room has not closed yet (not marked flown or cancelled).
Columns	Blue: today. Dark: weekend. Red: public holiday.

The coloured chips above the grid (Flight, Sim, Ground Duty, Squadron Duty, Leave, Off, Admin, Medical, Oversea Duty) are the legend for the activity colours.

2.6 Pilot: AC and Pax

In the Pilot plan, the right-click list of a flight cell also lets you mark the **AC** (aircraft captain). The pilot marked AC takes the Captain seat on the Ops Room board and on the AFP; with no mark, the most senior pilot does. The same works on standby (P1, P2, BU). Any department can mark a person as **Pax** on a flight: they ride along but are not crew.

2.7 Crew Roster



The Crew Roster. Regular crew at the top, then SANS and NSMEN.

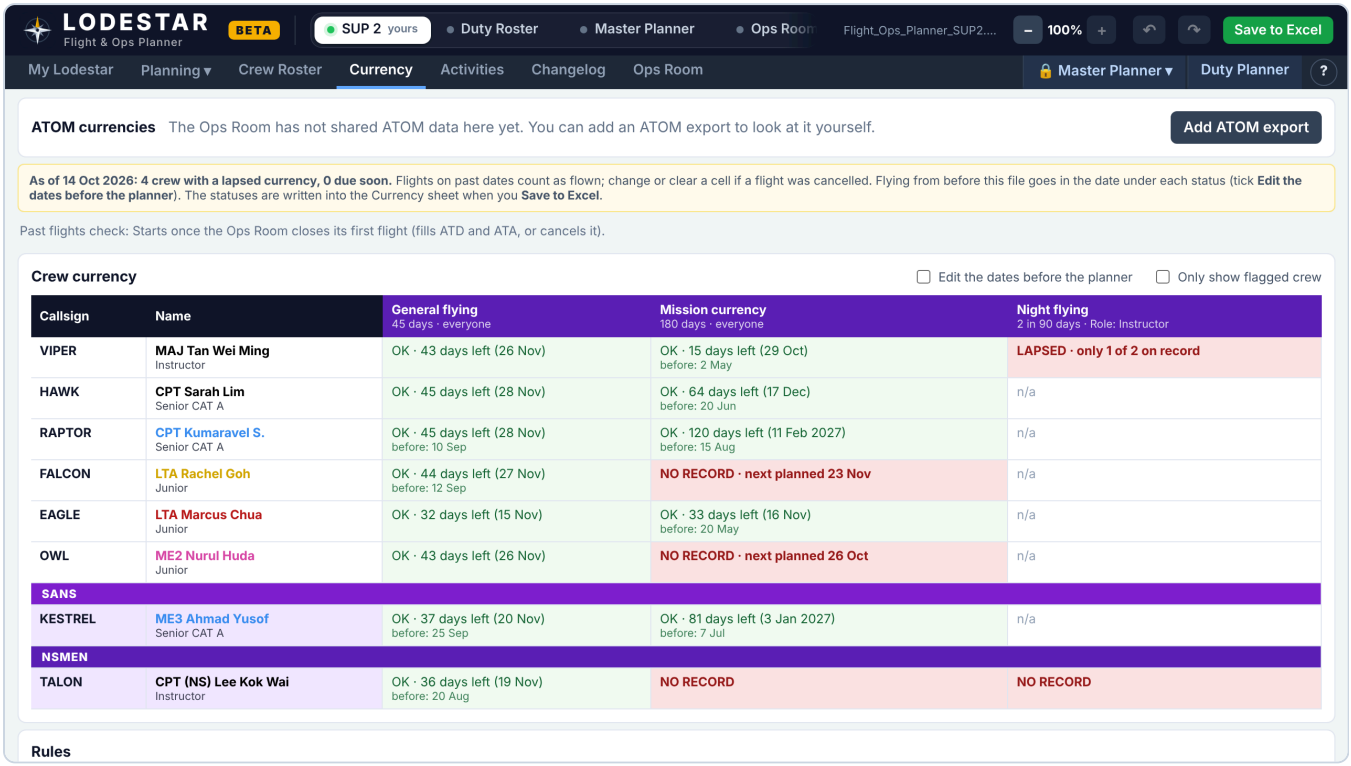
Your department's crew list: callsign, rank, name, initials, Cat Status, role, status and remarks. Changes here show on every tab. The order here is the order on the Planner, the Ops Room and in Excel.

- **Add a person:** type in the next empty row of their group (regular, SANS or NSMEN).
- **Right-click a person** for: Insert crew above or below, Move up or down, **Sort...** (by Cat Status, rank, callsign, name or role, with a preview), **Transfer** to SANS, NSMEN or regular crew, and **Remove crew...**.
- A person's plans for every month move with them when you insert, move or sort.
- **+ Add rank...** and **+ Add role...** at the bottom of those drop-downs add a new one to your file.
- **Initials** must match the person's name in ATOM, so the currency can find them (section 2.8).
- The name colour follows the Cat Status: CAT A black, CAT B blue, CAT C yellow, CAT D dark red, TRAINEE violet.

SOMEONE LEAVES

To keep their history, set **Status** to **Inactive**. **Remove crew...** clears their row and plans and closes the gap. Never clear a person's row by hand to reuse it for someone else: the plans are tied to the row, so the old plan would carry over to the new person.

2.8 Currency



The Currency tab (demo file, no ATOM data shared yet).

ATOM currencies

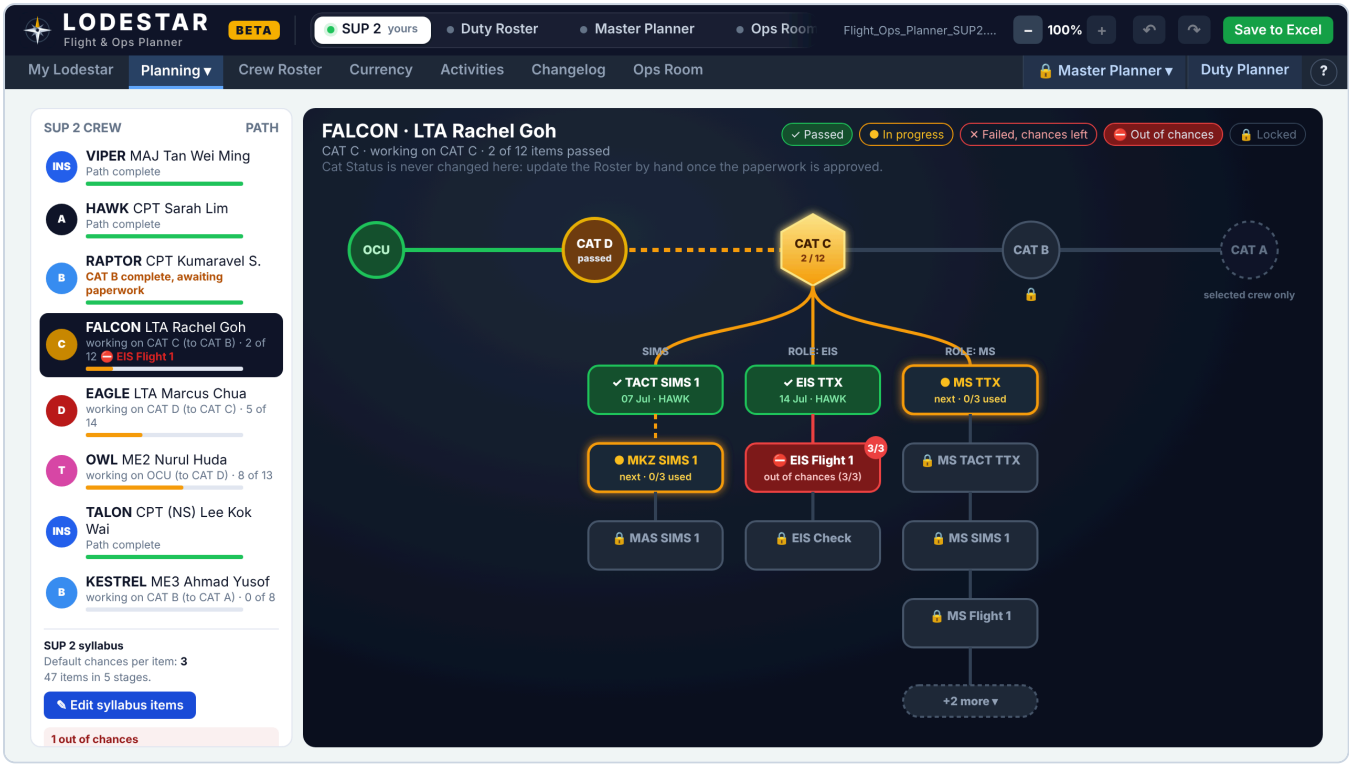
ATOM is the truth. Once a day the Ops Room adds the ATOM export and publishes it to everyone (the Ops Room guide). LODESTAR then shows for each person the Day Capt, Day Curr, IRT, Night Capt and Night Curr dates, the month's clocked hours and the mission currencies. Nothing else from ATOM is kept, and no names, only the initials.

- Red is expired, amber expires within 14 days (you can change the window), a dash is not held, and a hatched box is not recorded.
- **Names to fix** lists people LODESTAR cannot match, for example missing or wrong initials on the Crew Roster. It suggests the likely person: **Use as Initials** writes it in for you.
- On the Planner, the day a currency expires is marked in the person's row, and a flight after it shows a red corner and "NOT CURRENT". This only warns.

Rules table and the past flights check

Below the ATOM table are the older per-rule checks worked out from the plan. Right-click a rule to switch it off or remove it. A past planned flight counts as flown for these rules, so any flight in the last 45 days that the Ops Room has not closed is listed under the note and underlined amber on the Planner.

2.9 Syllabus Tracking

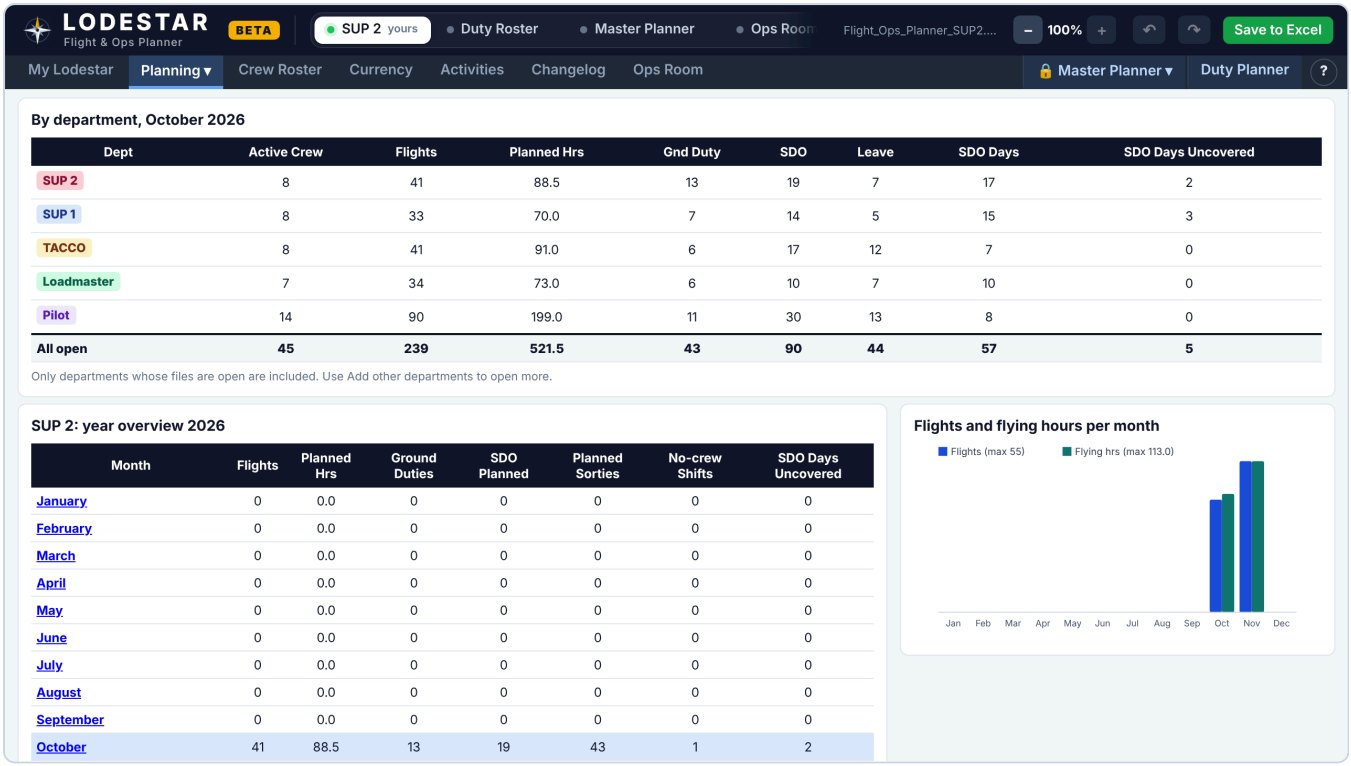


Syllabus Tracking for a crew member working on CAT C.

Under **Planning ▾**. Each person's training is shown as a path of stages along the top: **OCU, CAT D, CAT C, CAT B, CAT A**. Under the stage they are working on you see the tracks side by side, then the Check once the tracks are passed.

- **Enter a result:** click an item, type the date, instructor and remarks, then ✓ **Pass** or ✕ **Fail**. × deletes a wrong entry.
- **Plan it from the Planner:** right-click a crew cell, open the gold 🎓 **Syllabus** box and tick the item. The cell gets a gold corner. On the day, click the cell again to record Pass or Fail.
- **Chances:** each item has a number of chances. Fails before the first pass use them up. At 0 the item shows ⛔ **out of chances**. Nothing is blocked; it is a flag for the chain of command.
- When every item of a stage is passed it says **Stage complete, awaiting paperwork**. LODESTAR never changes a Cat Status: update the Crew Roster by hand once the paperwork is approved.
- The CAT A stage is instructor training. It opens only for CAT A crew selected for it: open the person and press **Select for instructor training**.
- ✎ **Edit syllabus items** changes the items and chances. An item that already has results is locked (🔒).

2.10 Overview, Activities and Miscellaneous Notes



Overview: every department for the month, then your department's year.

- **Overview** (under Planning ▾): flights, planned hours, ground duties, SDO and leave per department this month, and your department's year, with a chart. Click a month to open it on the Planner.
- **Activities**: the list behind the cell picker. The **Flights programme** part is filled from the Master Planner when you save. The **Ground programme** codes are yours to edit. The category decides each item's colour and which total it counts in. Public holidays are on the right.
- **Miscellaneous Notes** (under Planning ▾): a scratch sheet for your planners, like a small Excel sheet with bold, colours, borders and merge. Only your department sees it here. It is a hidden sheet in your Excel file, so keep personal data out.

2.11 Questions and problems

Problem	What to do
A flight is on the Master Planner but not on my MASTER row.	Press the copy button (section 2.4). If it is still missing, the flight's crew tags do not include your department: ask the Master Planner.
A flight code is missing from my list.	Save once. New codes from the Master Planner are added on save.
Someone shows "NOT ON LIST" on a duty.	Ask the Duty Planner to add them to that duty's crew list, or plan someone who is on it.
Currency says "Names to fix".	Make the person's Initials on the Crew Roster the same as their name in ATOM.
The Ops Room doesn't show my person in the seat.	Check they are on the flight code in the right shift, not on the WD row, and not marked Pax or down-chitted.
I put a whole-day item on AM.	Move it to the WD row. Whole-day items belong there.

PART 3

Duty Planner

BDO (Base Duty Officer) and SDO (Squadron Duty Orderly)

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QS Quick start

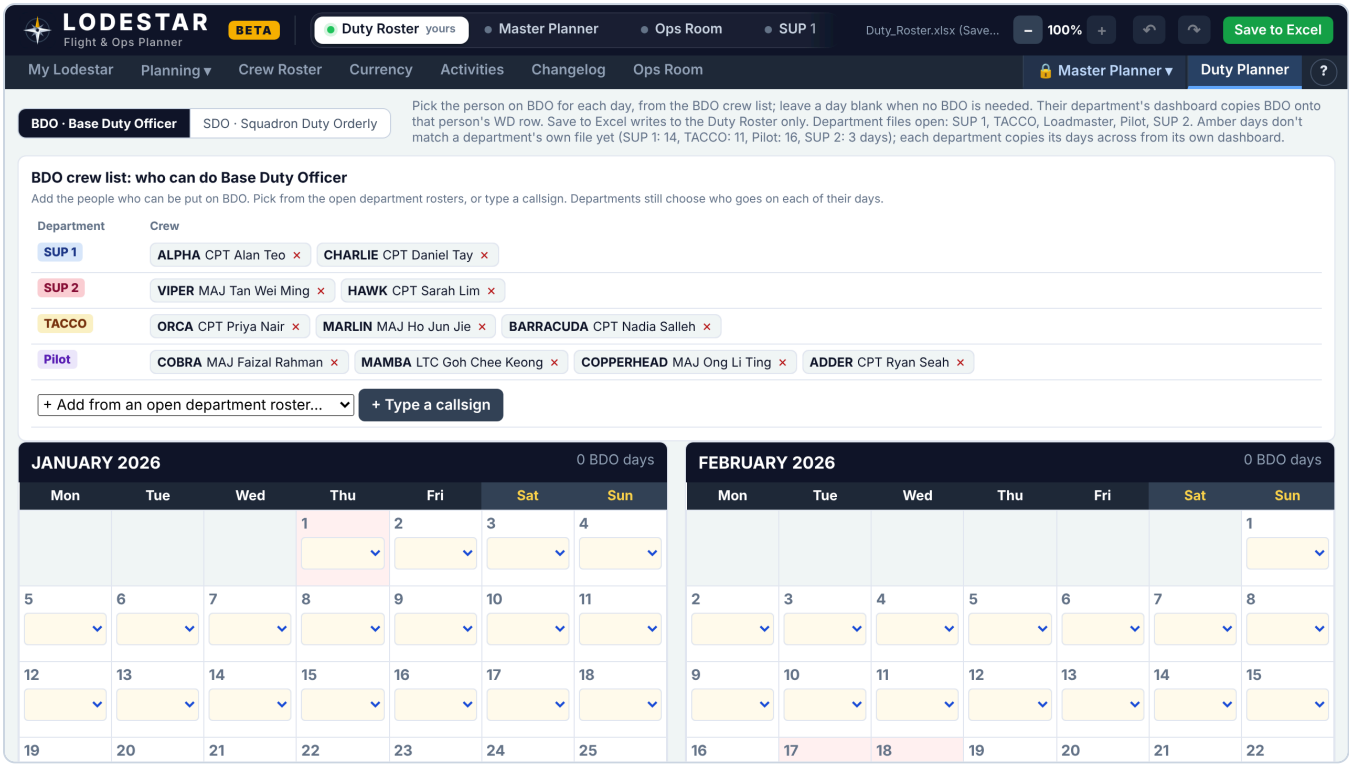
1. **Open the dashboard** and pick **Duty Roster** on the department screen, then the **Duty Planner** tab.
2. **Check the crew lists**: who may do BDO, and who may do SDO.
3. **BDO:** for each day, pick the person from the drop-down. Leave a day blank when no BDO is needed.
4. **SDO:** switch to **SDO · Squadron Duty Orderly** and pick the department for each day.
5. **Let it save.** Each department then copies its days into its own planner.

3.1 How duty planning works

Duty	The Duty Roster says	The department then
BDO	The **person** on duty each day, picked from the BDO crew list. A blank day means no BDO is needed.	Copies the days. BDO goes on that person's WD row.
SDO	The **department** on duty each day.	Copies the days and chooses who in the department does it, by putting SDO on that person's row.

The Duty Roster only changes the Duty_Roster.xlsx file. Nothing in a department's plan changes until that department copies its days.

3.2 The duty crew lists



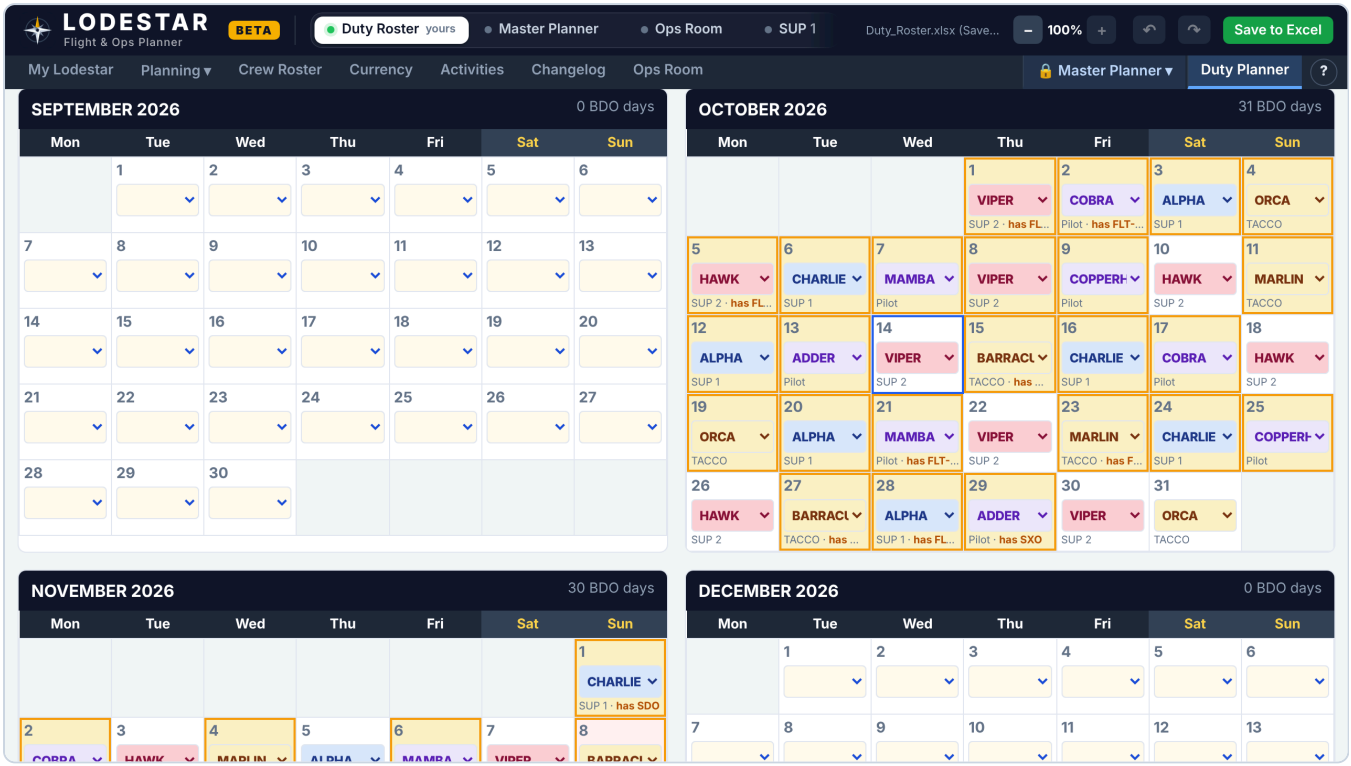
The Duty Planner, opened from the Duty Roster: the BDO crew list and the year's calendar.

At the top of each duty is its crew list: who may be put on that duty, grouped by department.

- **+ Add from an open department roster...** picks a person from the departments' Crew Rosters.
- **+ Type a callsign** adds someone by callsign.
- **×** on a name takes them off the list.

If a department plans the duty for someone who is not on the list, their cell is marked **NOT ON LIST** with a red dashed outline.

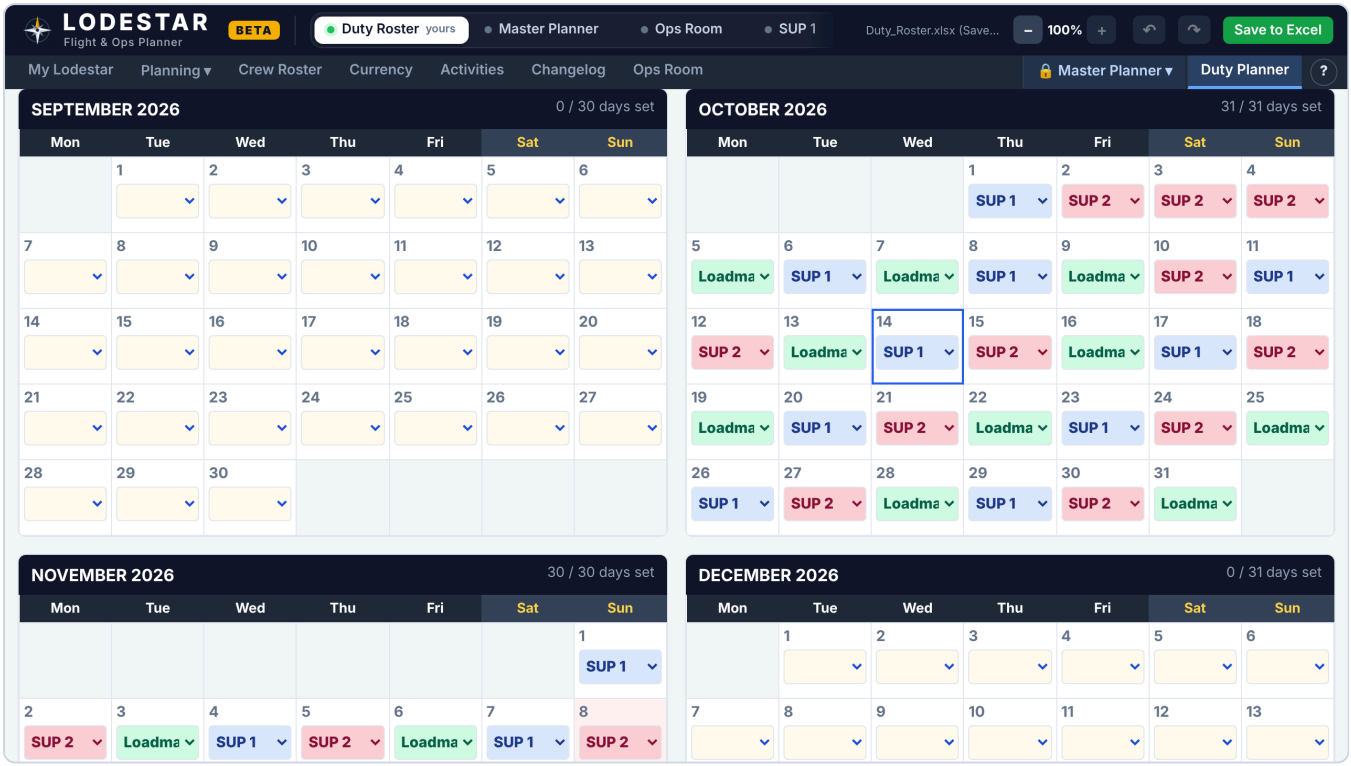
3.3 Planning BDO



BDO for October: one person per day, coloured by their department.

- Each day has a drop-down of the BDO crew list, grouped by department. Pick the person. The day takes the colour of their department, with the department's name under it.
- Leave a day blank when no BDO is needed. The month header counts the BDO days.
- **"has FLT-2.0"** under the name means that person already has something else planned that day. The day turns amber so you can check.
- An **amber day** also means that department's file does not match the roster yet (they have not copied their days).
- Blue outline: today. Red: a public holiday.

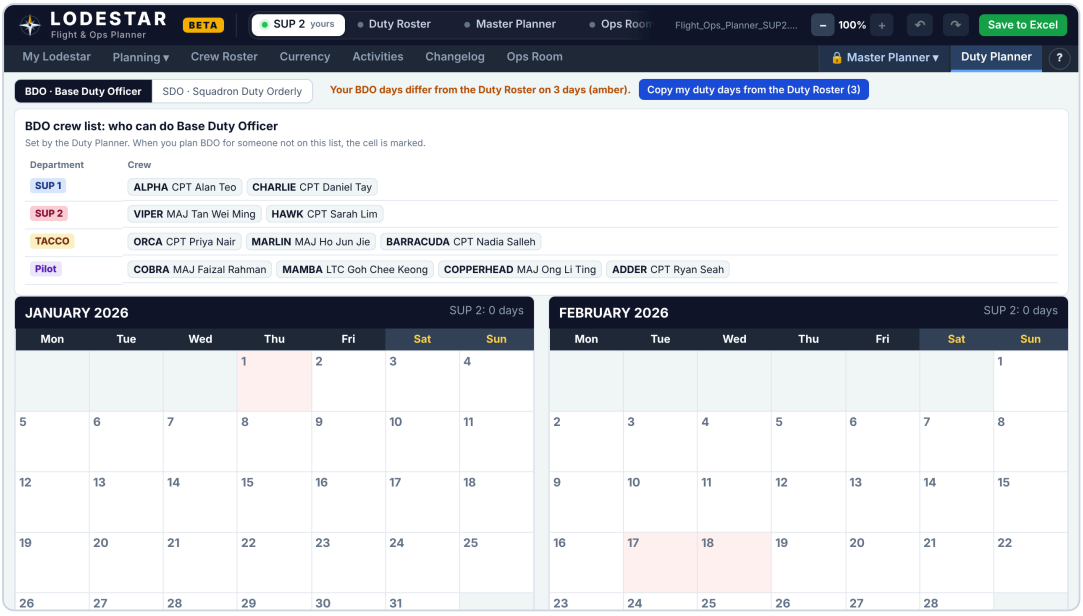
3.4 Planning SDO



SDO: one department per day.

- Switch with **SDO · Squadron Duty Orderly** at the top.
- Each day has a drop-down of the departments. Pick the department on duty. The month header shows how many days are set.
- A **red day** means more than one department is on duty. An **amber day** means a department's file does not match the roster yet.

3.5 What the departments do



The Duty Planner as a department sees it, with the copy button.

A department planner opens the **Duty Planner** tab from their own file. They can see the whole roster but cannot change it.

1. An amber line says how many days differ from the Duty Roster.
2. They press **Copy my duty days from the Duty Roster**.
3. **BDO** goes on the named person's WD row, and is taken off anyone else in the department that day. It asks before replacing something else in that cell.
4. **SDO** days appear on the department's DUTY DAYS row. The planner puts SDO on the person who will do it. Until then the day shows red.

> **THE OPS ROOM**
>
> The Ops Room duty strip shows the BDO and SDO for the day from these plans. Before a department copies its BDO days, it shows the roster's person, for example "MAMBA (Pilot)".

3.6 Questions and problems

Problem	What to do
A person is missing from the BDO drop-down.	Add them to the BDO crew list (section 3.2).
Days stay amber.	That department has not copied its duty days yet. Ask its planner to press the copy button.
A department's SDO day stays red on their Planner.	Nobody in the department has SDO on that day. The department planner must put someone on it.
A person shows "not in your Crew Roster".	The callsign on the BDO list does not match anyone in that department's Crew Roster. Check the callsign.